A universal favorite, this soup has a zingy parsley and lemon finish. It can also be made with leftover meat and the carcass of a roasted chicken.

traditional chicken soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 2½ HRS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
BEFORE HALF-AND-HALF IS ADDED

for the stock
1 small to medium free-range chicken
1 large carrot, chopped
1 leek, cut into segments
3 garlic cloves, unpeeled
¾oz (20g) dried mushrooms
3 celery ribs, chopped
2–3 sprigs each of parsley and thyme
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper

for the soup
3½oz (100g) short grain rice or pearl barley
1½ tbsp vegetable oil plus 10g (¼oz) butter
½ large red onion, finely chopped
2 garlic cloves, crushed
9oz (250g) button mushrooms, thinly sliced
4 tbsp half-and-half
2 tbsp finely chopped parsley
2 tsp finely grated zest of an unwaxed lemon

1 For the stock, place the chicken in a large saucepan over low heat. Cover with water and bring slowly to a boil, skimming the surface as needed. Add the carrot, leek, garlic, dried mushrooms, celery, and herbs. Season lightly. Bring back to a simmer, partially cover, and cook for 1 hour.

2 Remove from the heat. Once cool, lift out the chicken, strip the meat from the carcass, and reserve. Return the carcass to the pan and boil for 1 hour. Let cool, strain through a sieve into a bowl, and chill the stock.

3 Soak the rice or barley in cold water for 30 minutes. Rinse and drain. Skim the fat from the chilled stock. You'll need 3¼ cups of stock for the soup recipe, but you can add boiling water if needed.

4 Put the oil and butter in a deep saucepan over medium heat. Add the vegetables and cook for 3–5 minutes. Add the rice or barley, and stir for 2 minutes. Add the stock and cook for 15–20 minutes. Shred about 7oz (200g) of the reserved chicken and add to the soup. Taste, season if necessary, and return to a simmer. Stir in the half-and-half, parsley, and lemon zest, and serve very hot.